

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

TUESDAY 22 SEPTEMBER 2026



STRUCK SEVENTY TIMES THIS YEAR, AND EARNING SIXTEEN PER CENT MORE THAN LAST (P3)

THE WORLD

The largest drone wave of the war, on the last day of voting — and three official counts of the same night that do not agree

THE LONG READ

Fiji sells fifty-three million dollars of kava and buys back seventeen. The root is becoming a label rather than a place

THE RABBIT HOLE

Falconry: the only hobby whose central skill is getting back something you have deliberately let go

THIS ISSUE • NO. 110

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FROM THE DESK

“I suppose it is tempting, if the only tool you have is a hammer, to treat everything as if it were a nail.”

Abraham Maslow, *The Psychology of Science: A Reconnaissance* (1966)

A quarter-point cannot reopen a strait. A fine cannot reach a classroom.

THE STRIP • AT MONDAY’S CLOSE

US 10-year (par)	4.96%	▼ -5bp
US 2-year (par)	4.76%	unchanged
Brent (Nov, settle)	\$100.34	▼ -3.4%
Gold (spot / oz)	\$4,343	▼ -0.91%
Bitcoin	\$86,576	▲ +7.0% 24h
VWRA (All-World)	\$194.42	▲ +1.44%
AGGU (global agg)	\$5.774	▲ +0.28%
STI	5,675.23	▲ +0.34%
USD/SGD	1.2750	▼ -0.05%

Monday 21 September closes. Bitcoin and USD/SGD are spot at 05:14 SGT this morning. Treasury yields are the official par curve, not the market close — the two run six to ten basis points apart.¹ Not advice.

WHAT THIS ISSUE KEEPS FINDING

The length of the instrument. A central bank raised rates into an oil shock and its chairman conceded the tool cannot touch a single price — then oil fell three and a half dollars because tankers moved again (p14). Ukraine has hit Russian refineries seventy times this year; refining profits are up sixteen per cent (p3).

SOURCES ¹ Treasury par yields from the US Treasury’s own daily yield-curve file for 21 September 2026; equity, fund, index and commodity levels as set out with their origins on p14. Brent is the November contract’s Monday settlement, not the continuous screen quote — the front month rolls this week and the two differ by more than four dollars. Gold is spot and is **not** a record: it sits roughly 22 per cent below the high of about US\$5,600 set in late January 2026, a figure itself reported in a range across sources.

And the other direction. Export controls written around one lithography machine did not stop the memory pitch reached without it (p7). Schools banned phones and in-class use rose (p12). A few hundred bars in Florida are setting the price of the root a Fijian village drinks (p21).

MOSCOW · THE LAST NIGHT OF VOTING

Ukraine sent the largest drone wave of the war at a country that was still counting ballots.

Three official tallies of the same night do not agree. The refinery that burned is sixteen miles from the Kremlin — and Russian refiners, struck seventy times this year, have earned sixteen per cent more than last.

The ballots were still open. Overnight into Sunday 20 September, the last day of Russia's three-day State Duma election, drones reached Moscow and eighteen other regions, and the Moscow Oil Refinery at Kapotnya caught fire. Mayor Sergei Sobyenin said more than sixteen hundred had been intercepted, four hundred and fifty of them heading for the capital, and that the attack was "clearly planned with the aim of disrupting the elections."¹

The defence ministry said eleven hundred and ten, across nineteen regions, against a 2026 high of eight hundred and twenty-two in August.² A third figure, higher again, circulated in wire summaries; this desk could not read it anywhere and does not print it. The gap between the mayor and the ministry is roughly five hundred aircraft, unreconciled.

245,000

BARRELS A DAY AT THE MOSCOW REFINERY, ABOUT SIXTEEN MILES FROM THE KREMLIN. IT PROCESSED 11.6M TONNES OF CRUDE IN 2024¹

Three died in the Moscow region; four hundred residents, seventy of them children, left a twenty-one-storey block in Ramenskoye.¹ Russian strikes the same night killed four in the Kyiv region, three of them children. Volodymyr Zelensky said "one of Russia's key oil industry facilities... were hit."³

The count, at 95 per cent on Monday: United Russia 57.83 per cent, the Communists 13.81, New People 7.96. Three hundred and fifty-five seats of four hundred and fifty, the party's largest faction ever, on a turnout of 59.32 per cent that the commission's Ella Pamfilova called the highest ever for a Duma vote.⁴

Those figures come from Meduza, Al Jazeera and UPI; the commission's own site was not readable here.⁹

1,110 / 1,600

DRONES INTERCEPTED ON ONE NIGHT, PER THE DEFENCE MINISTRY AND PER THE MAYOR OF MOSCOW. NOBODY HAS RECONCILED THE TWO²

BEIJING

MFA BRIEFING, 21 SEP

Guo Jiakun: the elections are "an important event in Russia's political life, and the outcome reflects the will of the Russian people." China "firmly supports the choice independently made" there.⁷

BRUSSELS

KAJA KALLAS, 21 SEP

"Their outcome was never in doubt. The Kremlin silenced dissent, barred the only... party that opposed its war in Ukraine." Warsaw called the ballots held in occupied Ukraine "sham elections."⁸

THE SCEPTIC · SEVENTY STRIKES, AND THE MONEY WENT UP

The campaign against Russian refining is now a year old and the balance sheet cuts against it. Citing Rosstat and Euler analysts, the Ukrainian outlet *ua.news* reports Russian refineries earned about **\$12.3bn in the first half of 2026, up 16.2 per cent year on year**, even with roughly a fifth of capacity knocked out — held up by export bans and a fuel-price subsidy, with third-quarter petrol margins forecast 16.8 per cent higher at \$320 a tonne.⁶

The physical damage is real enough — Kirishi shut outright, Volgograd and NORSI at about a quarter, refineries hit more than seventy times since January, petrol output meeting only about seventy per cent of domestic demand.⁵ Both can be true. Hitting the plant and hitting the revenue turn out to be different operations.

SOURCES 1 *The Moscow Times*, 20 September 2026, read at source: Sobyenin's interception figures and quotation, the Ramenskoye evacuation, the fatalities and the refinery's 2024 throughput. 2 Bloomberg copy carried by the *Spokesman-Review*, 20 September: the defence ministry's 1,110 across nineteen regions, the August comparison, the refinery's capacity and its distance from the Kremlin. 3 Al Jazeera, 20 and 21 September: the Kyiv-region deaths, the Zelensky quotation, the parallel count and the NEST and Rybakov material. 4 Meduza, 21 September, for vote shares, the 355 seats and the turnout figure attributed to Pamfilova; the Central Election Commission's own site was not reachable and no figure here is read from it. 5 *Time*, 18 September. 6 *Kyiv Post*, September 2026, for the refinery damage tally. 6 *ua.news*, September 2026, reporting Rosstat and Euler analyst figures on refinery earnings — a Ukrainian outlet publishing a finding against its own side's campaign. 7 TASS, 21 September, for the Chinese foreign ministry briefing. 8 UPI, 21 September, for Kallas and the Polish foreign ministry. 9 Reddit and several wire services were unreachable from this desk throughout. Reuters, the BBC, the Associated Press, CNN and Reddit all refused this desk; nothing on this page is attributed to any of them.

WASHINGTON · A CHANNEL WITH NO PENALTY ATTACHED

Xi arrives on Wednesday. The offer on the table is a telephone nobody is obliged to pick up.

China's foreign ministry confirmed the state visit in a single paragraph. The American proposal that will meet it — a notification mechanism for artificial-intelligence incidents — carries no obligation, no penalty and, so far, no private-sector seat.

Beijing's confirmation ran to one sentence. "At the invitation of President of the United States of America Donald J. Trump, President Xi Jinping will pay a state visit to the United States from September 23 to 25."¹ His first there since 2015, and the return leg of a pair: Trump went to Beijing in May. A rare airport welcome is expected.²

What will be put to him was disclosed by Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on Saturday, after talks with Vice-Premier He Lifeng in New York: a mechanism by which each side would tell the other about artificial-intelligence incidents grave enough to touch national security. Moving "from opaque to more transparency between the No. 1 and the No. 2 AI powers in the world is very important," he said.⁵

BEIJING

GLOBAL TIMES, 21 SEP

Guo Jiakun: "Head-of-state diplomacy plays an irreplaceable role in providing strategic guidance to China-US relations." Fudan's Xin Qiang reads the visit as "a willingness to keep the relationship stable despite differences."³

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE CHANNEL CANNOT DO

The *South China Morning Post's* reading is that the mechanism is unenforceable by construction: no penalty for reporting late, withholding detail or misleading, and no seat for the laboratories that are the actual incident surface.⁷ The precedent cuts the same way — the 2008 military crisis line has largely gone unused by Beijing.

Against that, **Scott Singer** of the Carnegie Endowment: "Competition and cooperation can coexist... having an AI risk channel is a necessary precondition to mutually beneficial cooperation."⁶ Radio Free Asia adds a domestic reading: **Ding Wang** argues images of Xi negotiating with Trump "serve to boost the perception that Xi is still a capable leader" before next year's Party Congress.⁴

PONTIANAK · THE FIRES, AND WHO IS BEING SUED FOR THEM

A coalition calling itself *Nafas Kalimantan Barat* — the breath of West Kalimantan — has filed a class action at Pontianak District Court, case 292/Pdt.G/2026/PN Ptk, naming President Prabowo Subianto, six ministers, the police chief and the provincial governor.⁸ The filing date is given variously as 17, 19 and 20 September and is held; the case number is not in doubt. First hearing 7 October.

Acute respiratory infections are running at eight hundred to twelve hundred a day in Kubu Raya.⁸ Indonesia is fighting its most intense wildfires in eleven years, and officials warn they may burn into November.⁹ That smoke was over Singapore this morning (p5).

THE CHATTER · IT HAS BEEN TRIED, AND IT WORKED, AND THEN IT DIDN'T

An almost identical citizen suit against Joko Widodo over the 2015 fires **won at district court and was overturned by Indonesia's Supreme Court in 2022**, after the government petitioned for review.⁹ The plaintiffs' lawyer **Glorio Sanen** frames the new action as answering "the West Kalimantan public's concerns over the government's negligence." The court reached the government once. It did not reach the fires.

IN BRIEF

"Crimes against humanity of murder." The UN special rapporteur on counter-terrorism, **Ben Saul**, published a briefing note on Monday finding reasonable grounds to believe that a year of American strikes on alleged drug boats — **68 attacks, 223 dead** since September 2025 — amounts to "serial extrajudicial killings."¹⁰ US Southern Command says the campaign has stopped 97 per cent of illegal drugs entering by sea. The rapporteur's own figures are used above; the OHCHR release itself refused this desk twice.

SOURCES 1 Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs, announcement of 21 September 2026, read in full at fmprc.gov.cn; the quoted sentence is the entire release. 2 *South China Morning Post*, 21 September, for the ministry's expanded remarks and the expected airport welcome. 3 *Global Times*, 21 September, for Guo Jiakun, Wang Yi and the Fudan and CAITEC analysts. 4 Radio Free Asia, 18–19 September, for Ding Wang. 5 Associated Press copy carried by ABC News, 20 September (Matt Sedensky), for Bessent's remarks, the venue and the Board of Trade; no Treasury or Xinhua release on the mechanism could be located, and the on-record material is his remarks to reporters. 6 Al Jazeera explainer, 21 September, for the 1997 and 2008 precedents and the Singer quotations. 7 *South China Morning Post*, 21 September, on the mechanism's enforceability. 8 *Tempo* English, September 2026, for the case number, the plaintiffs, the health and visibility figures; the court docket itself was not readable. 9 Reuters copy carried by *The Business Standard*, for the Sanen quotation, the eleven-year comparison and the 2016 suit's reversal in 2022. 10 UPI, 21 September, and Reuters copy via Yahoo, both read at source, for the Saul findings; the OHCHR press release returned 403 twice and its body is not quoted here.

THE LAW · A NEW OFFENCE, AND THE SIZE OF THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

From Monday, breaking the casino limit your family asked for can cost you a year.

Over the past decade, between three and fourteen families a year applied for a Family Visit Limit, and about five people a year broke one.

The second tranche of the Casino Control (Amendment) Act 2024 took effect on Monday, and the headline change is small, precise and strange. A Family Visit Limit — the order a relative can ask the National Council on Problem Gambling to place on a family member — is now enforceable by the courts, at up to a year's jail or a ten-thousand-dollar fine.²

The rest is heavier than the headline. The burden of proof has moved: an excluded person is liable if they “know, or ought reasonably to know” their status. Withdrawing a bet once the result is known becomes an offence. Operators must share patron information for anti-money-laundering purposes.¹

One genuinely useful change sits underneath: the council can now convert an Exclusion Order into a Visit Limit immediately, where the swap took one to two months. A real administrative reach into a real problem, arriving in the same instrument as the jail term.

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A YEAR IN PRISON IS FOR

The numbers invite the question. A penalty of up to twelve months has been created for conduct the ministry's own records put at roughly five instances a year, by people whose families have already identified them as unable to stop.

Two readings are available and the evidence does not choose between them. Either the offence is symbolic — priced for its signal rather than its caseload — or the Visit Limit clauses are the visible part of a tranche whose real payload is the anti-money-laundering machinery that arrived alongside them. No named critic could be found in the window, and the regulator's own media page returned nothing. The silence is worth recording.

THE NUMBER THAT WILL MATTER MORE

The Manpower Ministry published its second-quarter Labour Market Report the same day. Employment rose 11,400 — a nineteenth consecutive quarter of growth — and unemployment held at 1.9 per cent.³ Beneath that, retrenchments reached **4,620**, the highest since the fourth quarter of 2020.⁴

The sharper figure is what happens next. In the ministry's own words, “the proportion of retrenched residents who re-entered employment within 6 months post-retrenchment fell from 60.7% in 1Q 2026 to 54.9% in 2Q 2026.”³ Vacancies fell to 68,600; resident employment growth more than halved to 2,200 while non-residents added 9,200.⁴

THE CHATTER · THE FORUM READS IT INSIDE OUT

Reddit was unreachable all session; the Singapore voice here is HardwareZone's EDMW board, whose thread ran to eleven pages and 208 replies by Monday.⁵ The posters quote the inverse of the ministry's statistic — the 45.1 per cent who did not find work. **ramlee:** “tahan 3 more months and the 45.1% will be categorized as ‘not actively looking for job’” A 1.9 per cent unemployment rate and a 54.9 per cent re-entry rate are both true. Only one describes being out of work.

ALSO THIS WEEK

Feet off the seat, from Wednesday. New regulations extend the MRT conduct regime to buses and interchanges from 23 September: up to **S\$500** for feet on seats, loud audio, eating or littering; up to **S\$5,000** for obstruction or soiling. Inspectors may issue notices; bus captains may order a passenger off but not book them.⁶

And the smoke arrived. At five this morning the twenty-four-hour PSI read **83 central**, 76 west, 72 east, 68 south, 63 north — moderate throughout — with one-hour PM2.5 at 37 micrograms centrally, read from the agency's live endpoint as this edition closed.⁷ The regional meteorological centre counted **699 hotspots in Kalimantan** on 20 September.⁸ Those are the fires being litigated in Pontianak (p4).

SOURCES 1 Ministry of Home Affairs, “Second Tranche of Amendments to the Casino Control (Amendment) Act 2024 to Take Effect on 21 September 2026,” read in full at mha.gov.sg; all clause detail and the quoted phrases are from that release. 2 AsiaOne, 21 September 2026, for the penalty and for the application and breach counts over the past decade — the only news account of the tranche this desk could read, and printed as such. 3 Ministry of Manpower, Labour Market Report Second Quarter 2026, published 21 September, read at mom.gov.sg and stats.mom.gov.sg; the re-entry sentence is quoted verbatim from the release. 4 AsiaOne and People Matters SEA, 21 September, for the comparison with the fourth quarter of 2020 and the minister's remark. 5 HardwareZone EDMW thread on the report, read 21–22 September; usernames as posted. 6 AsiaOne, Mothership and The Star, 21 September, all read at source and consistent; the Land Transport Authority's own newsroom returned 404 on every path tried, so the quoted words are second-hand by three independent routes. 7 National Environment Agency live air-quality endpoint, reading timestamped 05:00 SGT on 22 September 2026, read directly. 8 ASEAN Specialised Meteorological Centre hotspot counts for 20 September, read at AsiaOne; the centre's own page served a template shell with no data.

BARWARE • THE TIN, THE TENSION AND THE FENCE THAT GOT TRADEMARKED

A twenty-seven-dollar pair of tins and a hundred-and-sixty-five-dollar pair are the same alloy. Above that you are buying tolerance.

The seal is not made by the metal but by atmospheric pressure and two rims that are round. And the most famous name in the trade will not say where its steel is pressed.

The numbers on the box are mostly theatre. “18/8” is trade shorthand for eighteen per cent chromium and eight per cent nickel; **type 304 is specified at 18–20 and 8–11**, so the two are the same steel under different naming systems — making “18/10” a nickel flourish *inside the same alloy band*.¹

The genuine step up is **316**, which adds molybdenum and resists chlorides — the attack behind pitting from salt and detergent. Almost nobody in barware uses it. Yukiwa’s Baron is 18-8; Koriko tins are 18/8; BIRDY. is 18-8.² The US\$26.98 set and the US\$165 set are, on paper, identical steel.

So what does the money buy? Geometry. A Boston shaker seals because **steel flexes and glass does not**: the small tin bites the large tin’s wall along a short arc, and the shake does the rest — the trapped air chills, its pressure falls, the atmosphere clamps the joint. That is why the release is a palm strike where the rims sit furthest apart. **The roundness of two rims is the product**, and a dropped tin is a dead tin. Cobblers fail the other way: a small contact ring and no flat surface to strike, so they freeze shut.³

Two makers deserve their names. **Yukiwa** is Sampo Sangyo of Tsubame, Niigata — whose own trade profile says it accepts OEM manufacture, so Yukiwa is itself a white-label house.⁴ **BIRDY.** is stranger: made by Yokoyama Kogyo, an *automotive parts factory* in Toyota City, its mirror finish from polishing developed for car moulds.⁵

THE SCEPTIC • A JAPANESE FENCE, TRADEMARKED IN NEW YORK — AND AN ORIGIN NOBODY WILL STATE

Cocktail Kingdom’s own FAQ answers the question by **declining it**: “Our products are manufactured in Europe, Asia and the United States. For a specific product please contact us.”⁶ The firm knows how to label Japanese manufacture — its Hard Strong glassware carries “Made in Japan”. Its Koriko tins, Leopold jiggers and Yarai glasses carry no origin statement at all. **The absence is the finding**. “Yarai” was never a brand: a *yarai* is a lattice of bamboo, a Japanese fence — now a registered Cocktail Kingdom trademark.⁷

Received wisdom inverts too: the trade says a weighty mixing glass stirs a better drink, but **Dave Arnold measured it and found the vessel steals the chill** unless pre-chilled.¹⁰ At 27.9°C and 82 per cent humidity that is the technique here.¹¹ Plating is the other local trap.⁸ Buy bare steel.⁹

TIERS, AND THE LOCAL REALITY

~US\$80 buys entry-of-quality: Koriko tins \$26.98, Koriko Hawthorne \$21.99, OXO jigger \$12, a pint glass you own.

~US\$217 adds what tolerance buys — an Otsuka Maru-T seamless glass at \$48, a Yukiwa jigger at \$36 with interior hairlines. ~US\$430–530 buys finish, not accuracy.¹² Sia Huat and ToTT stock only trade-generic, so you will be importing — and Tokyo’s BAR TIMES STORE, which refuses US shipping, ships here normally.¹³ Mind the S\$400 GST line.¹⁴

NEXT ON THE BENCH — PICK THE NEXT CATEGORY

Coffee grinders — burr geometry is most of the cup.

Hard-shell luggage & carry-ons — polycarbonate against aluminium.

Fountain pens (the pen itself) — the nib, and the gold question.

SOURCES 1 Alloy specifications for type 304 and the 18/8 and 18/10 trade designations, read at Xometry and Bridge Fasteners; the molybdenum content and chloride behaviour of 316 from the same. 2 Steel grades read on the makers’ and retailers’ own product pages: Yukiwa Baron at Japanese Taste, Koriko tins and Hawthorne at cocktailkingdom.com, BIRDY. at BAR TIMES STORE. 3 America’s Test Kitchen equipment reviews of cocktail shakers and of Hawthorne strainers, read at source, for the seal comparison, the cobbler failure modes and the 0.5mm coil measurement. 4 JETRO’s Niigata company profile of Sampo Sangyo and the maker’s own site, for the founding date, the Tsubame address and the OEM statement. 5 BAR TIMES STORE’s account of Yokoyama Kogyo, for the Toyota City factory, the automotive polishing origin and the yen prices. 6 Cocktail Kingdom’s own FAQ page, quoted verbatim; the “Made in Japan” labelling pattern was established by searching the company’s own store and reading the bullet lists of the Yarai Seamless 550ml and Koriko tin listings, neither of which carries any origin string. 7 *Punch*’s profile of Greg Boehm for the Leopold and Koriko namings; the Nara National Research Institute for Cultural Properties for the yarai fence. 8 *Cocktails With Suderman*, “Notes on bar tools,” read at source. 9 tommacy.com, on mixing glasses and barspoons. 10 Dave Arnold, *Cooking Issues*, read at source. 11 Meteorological Service Singapore climate page for the annual mean temperature and humidity. 12 Prices read at cocktailkingdom.com, MTC Kitchen, Umami Mart and Kimura Glass in September 2026; the Kold-Draft figure is from the manufacturer’s own suggested list dated 1 September 2022 and is three years stale — current pricing will be higher. 13 store.siahuat.com and shop.tottstore.com, both read at source; Tangs could not be verified and is not listed. 14 BAR TIMES STORE’s shipping page for the US embargo; IRAS for the low-value-goods GST threshold in force since 1 January 2023.

HEFEI · A PITCH REACHED THE LONG WAY ROUND

China's memory maker says it is at 11.95 nanometres. It got there without the machine the export controls were written about.

The number is not a node name, and the company has published none of the figures that would let anyone check it. What it does establish is that quadruple patterning went where extreme ultraviolet was supposed to be required.

ChangXin Memory Technologies announced on Sunday 20 September, at the World Manufacturing Convention in Hefei, that its fifth-generation DRAM platform has entered mass production. The specific claim is an active-area half-pitch of **11.95 nanometres**, achieved with self-aligned quadruple patterning — four exposures and two spacer steps on older deep-ultraviolet machines, rather than one pass of an extreme-ultraviolet scanner that China cannot buy.¹

With it come two LPDDR5X parts at 24 gigabits per die, in 496- and 245-ball packages. CXMT says the array capacitor runs at a 45:1 aspect ratio and the platform yields at least fifty per cent more dies per wafer than its fourth generation.¹ The company took 9.5 per cent of global DRAM revenue in the second quarter, fourth behind Samsung, SK hynix and Micron.²

4 → 1

LITHOGRAPHIC EXPOSURES PER LAYER UNDER QUADRUPLE PATTERNING AGAINST A SINGLE EUV PASS. COST AND CYCLE TIME ARE THE PRICE OF THE DETOUR

9.5%

CXMT'S SHARE OF GLOBAL DRAM REVENUE IN THE SECOND QUARTER — FOURTH, BEHIND SAMSUNG, SK HYNIX AND MICRON²

CXMT's vice-president Luo Xiaodong says the process capability has “reached a level on par with the most advanced nodes now in mass production.”⁴ That is the sentence the rest of this page is about.

THE SCEPTIC · THE NUMBER MEASURES ONE STRUCTURE, AND NOTHING ELSE WAS PUBLISHED

The technology outlet *XenoSpectrum* makes the point most precisely: 11.95 nanometres is **not a node name**. It is half the repeat pitch in the array's active region, and “simply placing this number alongside figures like ‘3nm’ or ‘2nm’ used for CPUs and logic semiconductors invites confusion.”⁵ The *Seoul Economic Daily* reaches the same conclusion independently: the figure “measures one specific core structure and is therefore difficult to compare directly” with the twelve-nanometre-class names the three incumbents use.⁴ What CXMT did not publish: yields, good-die counts, operating speed, power consumption, charge retention at a 45:1 aspect ratio, monthly wafer input, any named customer, or a quantified cost reduction. The two “fifty per cent” claims rest on different baselines — bits per die in one case, gross dies per wafer in the other. No teardown exists. Every figure on this page is the company's own.

THE CHATTER · A SHRUG WHERE THE ARGUMENT SHOULD BE

Reddit was unreachable all session. On Hacker News, where CXMT's LPDDR6 story drew **42 points and 31 comments** on 9 September, the G5 announcement managed **3 points and no comments**.⁶ The audience that argued hard about a product two weeks ago had nothing to say about a process claim. The analyst **Ma Jihua**, in *Global Times*, keeps it modest: DRAM remains dominated by the three incumbents, and the advance “could strengthen China's indigenous innovation and technological self-reliance.”³ Acer's **Jason Chen** gives the buyer's view: Chinese capacity easing the memory shortage.⁴

SOURCES 1 ChangXin Memory Technologies newsroom, G5 platform announcement, 20 September 2026, read at cxmt.com; the half-pitch, aspect ratio, cell-array height, package ball counts, die capacity and dies-per-wafer claims are all the company's own and are printed as such. 2 TechNode, 21 September 2026, for the market-share position. 3 *Global Times*, 20 September, for Ma Jihua. 4 *Seoul Economic Daily* English edition, 20 September, for Luo Xiaodong, Jason Chen and the node-name caution. 5 *XenoSpectrum*, 21 September, read at source, for the half-pitch explanation, the two baselines and the list of undisclosed figures. 6 Hacker News item scores read through the Algolia index on 22 September; the LPDDR6 comparison is to CXMT's 9 September release. A monthly wafer-capacity figure circulating in aggregation is not printed here because it was not readable at any primary page.

THE BENCH · IT IS ON SALE THIS MORNING

The M5 Ultra reaches the shelf today, and the number that actually moved is not the one anybody quotes.

Token generation went up by about half. Prompt processing went up by a hundred and fifty per cent — and that is the number that decides whether a long-context agent is usable at home.

Announced 25 August, on sale today: the Mac Studio with M5 Max and M5 Ultra. This desk covered the announcement at No. 107 and held the rest against its own condition — real independent benchmarks, or the 512-gigabyte part shipping. The first arrived on Sunday; the second still slips to late October.¹

Apple's figures: up to a 36-core processor and an 80-core graphics unit, unified memory from 96 gigabytes to 512, and **1.2 terabytes a second** of bandwidth, at US\$5,499 for the Ultra with a terabyte of storage. The claim is up to 4.3 times the peak machine-learning compute of the M3 Ultra.¹

2,732 / 1,143

PROMPT-PROCESSING TOKENS PER SECOND, M5 ULTRA AGAINST M3 ULTRA, MEASURED INDEPENDENTLY. ROUGHLY A 150 PER CENT GENERATIONAL JUMP²

Federico Viticci's measurements at MacStories are the first substantial independent read. Generating tokens on a Qwen3.8 Flash model, the M5 Ultra ran 60 to 108 a second by context, against 37 to 70 for the M3 Ultra and 48 to 59 for an RTX 5090. The 5090 drew 577 watts at peak; the Mac was "appreciably quieter."²

But decode is bandwidth-bound once a model fits, and every Apple Ultra lands near the same effective figure. The gain is in the other half of the job — ingesting the prompt — which is compute-bound, and which is what a long context spends its time on.

THE SCEPTIC · THE REVIEWER'S OWN RESERVATIONS, AND THE THREAD'S

Viticci does not oversell it. The RTX 5090 still wins raw prompt-processing compute — about 3,000 tokens a second on a six-thousand-token prompt against the Mac's roughly 1,700 — and his 256-gigabyte unit **could not run a GLM-5.3 Flash model at full 256K context with both full precision and cache enabled**. The machine that exists to hold big models ran out of room.²

On Hacker News, where the review drew 207 points and 192 comments, the objection is price and method: commenters put the reviewed configuration at around twelve thousand dollars — a commenter's arithmetic, not a published figure, and not printed here as one — and framed it as more than a decade of a frontier-lab subscription. Others argue the 5090 comparison used suboptimal inference settings and claim north of 200 tokens a second with newer four-bit formats and multi-token prediction.³ Reddit was unreachable from this desk and no local-model forum is quoted here.

THE CHATTER · WHAT A HOME-LAB BUYER SHOULD TAKE FROM IT

The honest read is narrow. If the work is short prompts and long generations, a discrete card remains better value and the Ultra's advantage is quiet and watts. If the work is long-context agents, large codebases, retrieval over a corpus, the prompt-processing figure is the whole game — and that is where the generation moved. The 512-gigabyte part is the one worth waiting for, and it is not here yet.

STILL ON THE SHELF

The licence that is free and the runtime that is not.

PrismML's Ternary Bonsai 2 27B, covered at No. 108, has drawn its first independent scrutiny. The weights are genuinely Apache-2.0; the inference path is not upstreamed, and the model needs the company's own fork of llama.cpp rather than mainline. The loudest note in a 199-comment thread was exactly that. A separate independent retest of the first version concluded the benchmark lead "is not supported at the suite level," and that an aggregate moving from 72.59 to 84.78 "says nothing about agent wall time."⁴ A permissive licence behind a private fork is this year's version of open-washing: the grant reaches further than the road does.

SOURCES 1 Apple newsroom, "Apple introduces new Mac Studio with M5 Max and M5 Ultra," 25 August 2026, and apple.com/mac-studio/specs, both read at source, for core counts, memory ceilings, bandwidth, prices and availability. 2 MacStories, Federico Viticci, 21 September 2026, read at source, for all measured figures: token generation across three machines, prompt-processing throughput, memory footprint, the 5090's power draw and the GLM context failure. 3 Hacker News thread on that review, points and comment count read 22 September; the twelve-thousand-dollar configuration price is a commenter's arithmetic and is identified as such rather than printed as Apple's. 4 Hacker News thread on the Bonsai 2 launch (17 September) and a public retest issue on the first version, both read at source; the licence was confirmed on the model card itself. Singapore pricing for either machine was not retrievable and none is printed.

HEADPHONES · A VERY LARGE DRIVER AND A VERY THIN SHEET

FiiO's FT15 puts a 101-millimetre planar in walnut, and asks five hundred dollars for it.

The diaphragm is eight hundred nanometres thick — eighty-seven per cent thinner than the model it replaces. At twenty-four ohms it will run off a dongle, which quietly removes the usual second purchase.

The specification is the argument. FiiO's FT15, launched in China on 12 September at ¥2,999 and rolling out internationally through the month at **US\$499.99**, is an open-back planar magnetic headphone built around a 101-millimetre driver with an effective radiating area of 6,443.5 square millimetres — about thirty-five per cent more than its predecessor.¹

The diaphragm is where the engineering claim sits: **800 nanometres** thick, which the maker puts at 86.7 per cent thinner than the FT5's, carrying a full-surface diamond coating and a 28-nanometre electroplated voice coil. A thinner membrane has less mass to move and should settle faster; a stiffening coating is how you stop it flexing instead of pistoning. Quoted response runs to 40 kHz. The cups are North American black walnut, so no two pairs match. It weighs 425 grams.¹

24Ω / 95 dB

IMPEDANCE AND SENSITIVITY — LOW ENOUGH AND LOUD ENOUGH TO DRIVE FROM A USB DONGLE. THE AMPLIFIER IS NOT A REQUIRED SECOND PURCHASE¹

That matters more than the driver size for a buy-once reader: a great many open-back planars are sold at a price that conceals a second one, a desktop amplifier to make them go. Ninety-five decibels a milliwatt at twenty-four ohms is a phone-and-dongle specification.

THE SCEPTIC · THE CABLE HAS BEEN IN A FREEZER, AND NOBODY HAS MEASURED THE HEADPHONE

Two things are worth separating. The first is that **no independent measurement of the FT15 has been published**. Every number on this page is FiiO's, including the ones with three significant figures; the maker's own product page does not even carry a price. One reviewer's impressions circulate in aggregation and this desk could not read them at source, so they are not quoted here. Judgement waits for a measured frequency response.

The second is the box. The supplied balanced cable is advertised as six-nines monocrystalline copper, **cryogenically treated for more than a hundred hours at minus 192 degrees**. This desk examined cable claims at No. 75 and found what is real — geometry, shielding, honest connectors — and what is not. A hundred hours in liquid nitrogen belongs in the second category until somebody publishes a before-and-after. It is the logo tax wearing a lab coat, and it is attached to a headphone whose actual engineering story needs no help.

THE CHATTER · THE OTHER OPEN-EAR RELEASE, AND WHAT ITS PREDECESSOR MEASURED

Bose announced a second generation of its Ultra Open Earbuds on 17 September, on sale 1 October at **US\$299**, unchanged: cuff-shaped, air-conduction, now nine hours of playback against seven and a half, Bluetooth 5.4, multipoint, aptX Adaptive, IPX4, and a new driver the company says goes deeper and louder.²

Nothing independent exists on it yet either. What does exist is SoundGuys' measured review of the first generation at the same \$299: "no bass response and a sharp spike in the upper midrange" against their preference curve, zero isolation by design, a microphone that "struggled to reject any wind noise" — and, to the company's credit, a measured 8 hours 53 minutes against a claimed 7.5.³ Bass is precisely what the second generation claims to have fixed. That is the measurement to go and find in October, and this desk will.

SOURCES 1 FiiO's own FT15 product page for the driver, diaphragm, coating, voice coil, impedance, sensitivity, response, weight, cup material and supplied accessories — the page carries no price; pricing and the China launch date from ecoustics and MajorHiFi, read at source. All performance figures are the manufacturer's; no independent measurement of this model has been published. A reviewer's reservation about macrodynamics circulates in aggregation but that page refused this desk, so it is not quoted. 2 Bose pressroom release, "Bose Sport Open Earbuds and Bose Ultra Open Earbuds (2nd Gen)," read at source, for price, battery, codecs, ingress rating and on-sale date; no Singapore price was obtainable and none is printed. 3 SoundGuys' measured review of the first-generation Ultra Open Earbuds, read at source, and clearly identified above as the previous model.

OBJECTS · A DIAL WITH NO FIXED PICTURE

Ressence milled a maze into titanium and then made sure it never sits still.

The discs turn continuously, so the artwork is never twice in the same place — and lines up to show a hidden word only at midnight and midday. Sixty pieces. All gone.

The Type 9 “Jules Wittock,” shown on 17 September, carries the name of the Belgian artist it was made with, and rests on a mechanism Ressence has built for years. The dial is not a dial: it is rotating discs — the ROCS 9 module on a customised automatic base, 182 components — on which the indications orbit rather than sweep.¹

Onto that surface the maze is cut into grade 5 titanium and hand-filled with white lacquer. Because the discs never stop, the pattern differs every minute, and the maze aligns with the sub-dial to reveal a hidden word **twice a day, at midnight and noon.**¹ An object whose picture you cannot hold still, and which completes itself on a schedule.

1 ATM

TEN METRES. A CROWNLESS CASE, SET THROUGH THE BACK — NOTHING TO UNSCREW, AND NOTHING TO SWIM IN¹

The case is titanium, 39mm by 11mm. There is no crown: time is set by turning the caseback, which is elegant and is also why the water rating is ten metres. Sixty pieces. **€26,200 including tax** — CHF20,000 before it, US\$28,900 in America.² Sold out everywhere.³

THE SCEPTIC · THE ARTWORK YOU CANNOT SEE FROM A METRE AWAY

The most useful notice came from a specialist who likes the watch and still says the quiet part. **Jack Shepherdson** at SJX judges that the maze “is abstract enough to simply read as an interesting dial pattern at arms length,” and that the design is “appealing on its own merits with or without the artist tie-in.”² Which is praise for the watch and a shrug at the premise: a collaboration whose collaboration is invisible at conversational distance.

One number this desk will not print: the weight. Ressence’s own Type 9 page says 39 grams; its American retailer says 42 with strap. Both cannot describe the same measurement, and neither says which. SJX identifies the base calibre as an ETA 2892 — worth knowing at twenty-six thousand euros, and not something the brand volunteers.

ESCAPES · AND A PLATTER THE MOTOR NEVER TOUCHES

Esoteric’s T-01 turntable, announced 21 August, ships worldwide at the end of this month — which is the peg. Its patented MagneDrive replaces the belt with a magnetic coupling: **there is no physical link between motor and platter at all**, and a Magne-Float system cuts the effective mass of a thirteen-kilogram platter to about four.⁴

THE CHATTER · LUST, AND A FAIR QUESTION UNDERNEATH IT

Michael Lavorgna at *Twittering Machines* reaches for “like sci-fi” and calls the separate power supply and dual-layer build lust-worthy — then asks the question that matters: whether anything here actually improves on the rotational accuracy of a good motor, which was already exceptional.⁵ A fair doubt about a fifty-thousand-dollar answer to a problem that may already have been solved.

US\$50,000 with the TA-9S arm, US\$46,000 armless. Those prices come from that review, not from Esoteric, whose release carries none; a Japanese outlet quotes a yen figure that does not reconcile, so no yen price is printed. And a correction other outlets have got backwards: in Esoteric’s own words “**AL**” means **armless** — it is not the name of the tonearm.

SOURCES 1 Ressence’s own Type 9 Jules Wittock page, read at source, for the module and base calibre description, the component and jewel counts, the power reserve, the case dimensions and coating, the titanium dial and hand-filled lacquer, the edition size, the euro price and the midnight-and-midday alignment. 2 SJX (Jack Shepherdson), 17 September 2026, read at source, for the ETA 2892 identification, the Swiss franc price and the quoted assessment. 3 Collective Horology’s product listing for the US price, the strap weight and availability. 4 Esoteric’s own press release of 21 August 2026, read at source, for the patented magnetic drive, the platter mass reduction, the wow-and-flutter figure, the clock input, the dual-arm support and the armless designation; the release does not state prices. 5 *Twittering Machines* (Michael Lavorgna), 21 August 2026, read at source, for the dollar, euro and sterling prices and the quoted reservation. Hodinkee and Monochrome category pages were unreachable from this desk and nothing here is attributed to them.

MUSIC · A RECORD WITH A SHORT ADDRESS LIST

At seventy-nine, Haruomi Hosono made an album and said plainly that it was not meant for us.

“It was intended to be delivered to the people closest to me, sort of like a letter.” His first new material in seven years is also the first this desk has had to review knowing it was addressed elsewhere.

Yours Sincerely arrived on 11 September: Haruomi Hosono’s twenty-third album and his first new music in over seven years. He is seventy-nine, co-founded Yellow Magic Orchestra in 1978, and has spent five decades in exotica, ambient, bamboo music and video-game scores.¹

Nearly every track draws on his own back catalogue or the music he loves, and he has been explicit about the intent: “It’s not really a record written for the whole world. It was intended to be delivered to the people closest to me, sort of like a letter.”¹ An unusual thing to say on a release week, and it changes what a review is for.

23rd

STUDIO ALBUM, SEVEN YEARS AFTER THE LAST. “M FOR MANDALA” REACHES BACK TO HIS GLOBAL-STYLES PERIOD¹

Owen Hatherley, reviewing it as album of the week for *The Quietus*, reads it as “a summation, full of ideas that he has tried out elsewhere,” and finds it “really rather moving” — relaxed and cooling on the surface, with ambiguity underneath. He places the tracks against the 1970s exotica, the 1980s gamelan records and the game music, and concludes it distils those interests rather than breaking new ground.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE SAME REVIEWER NAMES THE COST OF THE COMFORT

Hatherley does not let the warmth pass unexamined. Beneath the record’s ease he hears “the sound of someone cocooning themselves in an idyllic, insular environment” — an album that soothes because it has withdrawn from what it might otherwise have had to face.²

Which is either the criticism or the point. A man who says he made a record for a short list of people has, by his own account, built exactly the insular room the review describes. Whether an artist of this stature owes the rest of us a wider address is a question this desk will leave open — but a seventy-nine-year-old declining to speak to the whole world is a position, not an oversight.

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE NUMBERS SIT, AND WHY ONE IS MISSING

Metacritic’s aggregate for *Yours Sincerely* reads **84**, taken from the site’s own new-releases listing.³ The album’s own Metacritic page refused this desk outright, so **the number of critic reviews behind that 84 is not printed here** — a secondary compilation gives a different score over fourteen reviews, and this desk is not going to reconcile two figures it could only read one of.

Elsewhere in the same fortnight: Echo & the Bunnymen returned with *Apples For Isaac*, their first since 2014, at a Metascore of 84; Carly Rae Jepsen’s twenty-four-track double *Day And Night* sits at 83; beabadoobee’s *Pylon* at 78.³ A strong fortnight, and the one that will still be played in twenty years is the letter.

STILL ON THE SHELF

The video-game film that outran its own genre. Zach Cregger’s *Resident Evil*, covered here at No. 108, has settled into the numbers that will define it: 95 per cent on Rotten Tomatoes from 219 critics and a Metascore of **81 from 45 reviews with not one negative notice** — against a B+ CinemaScore from the audience that paid.⁴ Empire’s Harry Stainer supplies the dissent the aggregate hides: it “more than clears the (fairly low) bar as best *Resident Evil* movie yet,” but “its surprise-free narrative stops it short.” Box-office figures circulating for the opening weekend sit behind paywalls this desk could not read, and none is printed.

SOURCES 1 Release date, album number, the seven-year gap, Hosono’s age and the “letter” quotation from the album’s own Bandcamp page and Bandcamp Daily’s album-of-the-day notice, read at source. 2 *The Quietus*, Owen Hatherley, 10 September 2026, read at source; all quotations and the contextual placement against his back catalogue are from that review. 3 Metacritic aggregate scores read from the site’s own new-releases and by-metascore listings on 22 September; the album’s individual page returned 403 and the critic count behind the score is therefore not printed. 4 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic pages for *Resident Evil* (2026), read at source on 22 September; the critic counts drift daily and are timestamped to that reading. Deadline, Variety and GoldDerby all sit behind a paywall redirect, so no box-office figure appears here.

SCHOOLS · A RULE THAT STOPPED AT THE CLASSROOM DOOR

They banned the phones. A year later, more teenagers were using them in class, not fewer.

Phone use during core lessons rose from 28 to 42 per cent across one school year. Forty-four per cent of students said teachers had got less strict; thirteen per cent of adults had noticed.

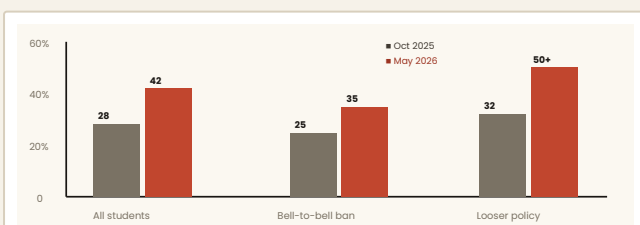
The finding comes from a panel that asked the same teenagers twice — in October 2025 and again in May 2026 — and it is not the result anyone expected. Across the school year, the share reporting phone use during core classes went **up, from 28 per cent to 42**. Under strict bell-to-bell bans it rose from 25 to 35. Under looser policies it rose from 32 to over half.¹

The mechanism the students describe is enforcement fatigue, not defiance. **Forty-four per cent said teachers had become less strict** over the year. Only 13 per cent of adults thought so. The rule did not change; the number of adults willing to spend a lesson enforcing it did.

That gap between the two figures is the finding. Adults were asked the same question and gave the opposite answer — which means the people writing the policy and the people living under it were describing different schools. A rule that is enforced on paper and abandoned in the fourth period will still be reported, by the adults, as working.

48% → 27%

SHARE OF STUDENTS UNHAPPY WITH THE POLICY, START OF THE YEAR TO END. THEY STOPPED MINDING AS IT STOPPED BITING¹



Share of students reporting phone use during core classes, over one school year. Every category rose; the loosest policies rose most, and so did the strictest. *Meridian* original, from the Understanding America Study panel as reported by Brookings.¹

The second half of that is the part worth sitting with. Student unhappiness with the restriction nearly halved. A policy can become popular precisely by ceasing to be a policy, and a survey that measured only sentiment would have called this a success.

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T BE ALARMIST — AND DON'T BE TRIUMPHANT EITHER

Before this is read as proof that bans fail, two cautions. The first is the desk's own: **the panel is described as nationally representative teenagers, and this desk could not verify at source that the sample contains twelve-year-olds**. A secondary account puts it at thirteen to seventeen. It is context for a Secondary 1 parent, not the study of record for that year group, and it is printed on that basis.

The second is a named dissent from the other direction. **Sonia Livingstone** of the LSE argued in a *JAMA Pediatrics* Viewpoint in April 2026 for allowing phones in schools with policies designed to reduce harm and support learning, rather than for prohibition.² Her broader position — that bans are an admission that regulators cannot govern the companies, so they govern children instead — circulates in press interviews this desk could not read at source, and is therefore summarised from her peer-reviewed Viewpoint alone rather than quoted.

THE CHATTER · WHAT THIS MEANS AT A SINGAPORE SECONDARY SCHOOL

Singapore's device rules tightened in January and this desk covered the local picture at No. 109. What the panel adds is not an argument for or against a rule but a warning about how to read one: **a policy's text and its reach are different quantities, and only the second one shows up in a child's day**.

The practical version, for a parent of a twelve-year-old: the question to ask at a parent-teacher meeting is not what the phone policy says. It is who enforces it in the fourth period on a Friday, and what happens when they don't. General guidance, not medical or educational advice.

SOURCES 1 Dan Silver, Amie Rapaport and Morgan Polikoff (USC Center for Applied Research in Education), "A year later: what teens tell us about school cellphone bans," Brookings, published 10 September 2026, read at source; the panel is the Understanding America Study, surveyed October 2025 and May 2026. All percentages above are from that article. The sample is described there as nationally representative teens; an explicit age range is not stated on the page, and a secondary account giving thirteen to seventeen could not be confirmed at source — flagged in the text rather than relied upon. 2 Sonia Livingstone, "The Case Against School Cell Phone Bans," *JAMA Pediatrics* 2026;180(4):362–363, published 1 April 2026 (PMID 41729532); the position above is taken from the journal's own summary of the Viewpoint. Quotations attributed to her in general press were not readable at source and are not printed.

EVIDENCE • THE LEVER PARENTS PULL HARDEST

Researchers deleted every hour of unhealthy adolescent screen time from a cohort of 6,608. It moved the outcome by two-tenths of a percentage point.

Physical activity did eight times as much work. The paper is about heart disease at forty, and about which childhood habit actually carries that far.

The method is worth understanding before the number. A causal decomposition takes a real cohort and asks a counterfactual: if this one behaviour had been healthy in every child, how much of the adult gap would have closed? The cohort here is Add Health — 6,608 American adolescents enrolled in grades 7 to 12 in 1994–95 and followed to adulthood in 2016–18.¹ American seventh-graders are twelve and thirteen, so the band contains her year. The paper does not print an age range, and neither does this desk.²

The gap: children of parents without a degree carried a higher thirty-year cardiovascular risk in adulthood — a risk difference of **6.9 percentage points**, a risk ratio of 1.73. Make every one of their movement behaviours healthy — activity, screen time and sleep, against the 24-hour movement guidelines — and the difference falls to 4.9 points.¹

-1.7 / -0.2 / -0.2

PERCENTAGE POINTS OF THE GAP CLOSED BY PHYSICAL ACTIVITY, BY SCREEN TIME, AND BY SLEEP, RESPECTIVELY¹

Two points of the gap, from every lever at once. Of that, physical activity did 1.7; screen time did 0.2; sleep did 0.2. The equalisation scenario — giving poorer children the habits of richer ones — had minimal effect. The risk ratio barely moved at all.

It is worth being clear about what a counterfactual of this kind is doing, because it is not an experiment. The authors take a real cohort, model what the outcome would have been had one behaviour been healthy in every child, and read off the difference. That makes it a statement about how much of the gap travels along each pathway — not about how much any individual child would benefit. A parent is not the population, and the paper does not claim otherwise.

6,608

ADOLESCENTS ENROLLED IN GRADES 7–12 IN 1994–95 AND FOLLOWED TO ADULTHOOD IN 2016–18¹

THE SCEPTIC • WHAT THIS DOES NOT SAY

It does not say screen time is harmless. It says that, as a route from adolescence to the socioeconomic gap in adult heart disease, it carries almost nothing — and that a household with finite authority is spending most of it on the smallest of the three levers. Sleep scored the same 0.2, which should trouble anyone who has fought both battles.

The honest limits: this is a decomposition of an observational cohort, not a trial; the behaviours were measured in the 1990s, when screen time meant television rather than a phone in a blazer pocket; and a 2026 twelve-year-old's screen is a categorically different object. The direction of the finding is robust. Its transportability to 2026 is the open question, and this desk flags it rather than assuming it.

THE CHATTER • AND THE THING THAT MAY OUTRANK ALL THREE

A second study, published on 8 September, followed 1,030 Chinese seventh- and eighth-graders across three waves at three-month intervals, mean age 13.24. Within individual children, **the academic performance of the specific peers they actually spent time with predicted both their later academic self-concept and their later achievement**, with self-concept and achievement feeding each other over time.³

The abstract reports direction and significance and no coefficients, so **no effect size is printed here** — the magnitude will be reported when the paper is readable in full. The mean age sits above twelve, so it is early-secondary evidence rather than twelve-year-old evidence. The plain reading stands anyway: not the school's ranking, not the tuition centre. The three or four children she eats lunch with. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 Grubic N, Maximova K, Chiolerio A, Siddiqi A, Carsley S, Batomen B, Carmeli C, “Contribution of Adolescent Movement Behaviours to Socioeconomic Inequalities in Adult Cardiovascular Disease Risk: A Causal Decomposition in a Population-Based Cohort,” *American Journal of Epidemiology*, published online 18 September 2026, DOI 10.1093/aje/kwag234, PMID 42757410; sample size, risk difference, risk ratio and the per-behaviour decomposition are from the abstract as published. 2 Add Health study-design documentation, read at addhealth.cpc.unc.edu, which specifies enrolment in grades 7–12 in the 1994–95 school year; the site does not state an explicit age range and none is asserted here. 3 Sun Y, Wang H, Lu B, Wang W, Wang H, Wang C, “How Peers Inform Adolescents’ Academic Self-Concept and Achievement,” *Journal of Youth and Adolescence*, online 8 September 2026, DOI 10.1007/s10964-026-02409-7, PMID 42709375; sample, mean age, wave structure and the direction of the within-person findings are from the abstract, which reports no numeric coefficients.

MARKETS · RELIEF FROM ONE SIDE OF THE LEDGER ONLY

The ten-year fell five basis points on Monday. The two-year did not move at all.

Oil broke below a hundred dollars because tankers started moving through Hormuz again — and the front end of the curve, which answers to the Fed and not the strait, refused to price a point of it.

Three central banks raised rates in ten days: the ECB to 2.50 per cent on 10 September, the Federal Reserve on the 16th to 3.75–4.00 — its first increase since 2023, unanimous — and the Bank of Japan to 1.25 on the 18th, a thirty-one-year high. The yen fell anyway.² A three-decade-high policy rate and the currency could not rally: USD/JPY has gone from 153.57 to **157.23** in a fortnight. That is a dollar bid on rate differentials, with the VIX at 14.87 and no fear in it.

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	MOVE
US 10-year (par)	4.96%	▼ -5bp
Brent (Nov, settle)	\$100.34	▼ -\$3.53

Monday's closes. VWRA \$194.42, +1.44%; US 2-year 4.76% par, unchanged; AGGU \$5.774, +0.28%; gold \$4,343, -0.91%; bitcoin \$86,576, +7.0% at 05:14 SGT. The Nasdaq set a record at 27,122.09; the S&P, at 7,764.70, did **not**. 2s10s +20bp, thirty narrower than a month ago.¹

What moved Monday was supply, not policy. Washington signalled openness to meeting Iran's president; Aramco loaded roughly fourteen million barrels onto seven supertankers on Sunday. Crude transiting Hormuz has averaged **2.9 million barrels a day over six days, against 700,000 in August.**⁶ Lower oil, lower expected inflation, lower long-end yields — and nothing at the front end.

"We cannot affect any individual price... What we can do is ensure that any change in relative prices don't broaden out." That is the Fed chair, Kevin Warsh, answering a reporter who put it to him that a quarter-point rise does not reopen the Strait of Hormuz.³ It is the most candid account of the instrument's limits any central banker has given this year — and the two-year is pinned because he also said he would be "hard-pressed to describe broad

financial conditions as restrictive," that September merely "removed a dose of accommodation," and, asked where policy sits against neutral, "in a word, no."

THE SCEPTIC · THE NUMBER UNDER THE RECORD CLOSE

Torsten Sløk of Apollo, against Monday's consensus: "The credit story in hyperscalers rests on a single consensus assumption, that operating cash flow triples from \$600 billion to \$2 trillion."⁹

A second doubt: headline inflation is 3.4 per cent, core 2.4, and the gap is energy.⁴ If Brent keeps sliding because tankers are moving, the Fed will have hiked into an impulse already resolving on the supply side — what Warsh's own answer concedes it cannot reach. A month ago futures priced a 53.6 per cent chance of an October cut; that is now zero.⁵

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BTC

The diversification is not working, and this desk computed it rather than asserting it. Realised correlation between VWRA and AGGU — the global sixty-forty pair — is **+0.69 over twenty days, +0.59 over sixty and +0.65 over six months**, all ending Monday; the short window sits above the long one, so it is tightening.⁷

The behaviour is worse than the coefficient. On 14, 15 and 16 September equities fell on all three days — and bonds fell on all three too. AGGU is hedged, so that is pure duration; gold sits 22 per cent below its January record and fell again on Monday *while oil collapsed*. When the shock is inflation rather than growth, one factor prices all four and bonds become an equity beta. **Explanation, not advice.**

One slope is working: on Monday **USD/SGD fell 0.05 per cent while the dollar index rose 0.18.**⁸

SOURCES 1 Levels for 21 September 2026: Treasury par yields from the US Treasury's own daily yield-curve file; VWRA and AGGU from the London close, VWRA cross-checked against Vanguard's own UK page (+1.42% on the sterling line); STI from the SGX close; US index closes and the VIX from exchange data; gold spot and its late-January record from Trading Economics, both of which carry a small spread across sources and are given as approximate. Brent is the **November contract's Monday settlement**, not the continuous screen quote — the October WTI contract expires this week and the curve is steeply backwardated, so the rolled series understates the front month by more than four dollars. 2 Federal Reserve statement and Summary of Economic Projections, 16 September 2026, read at federalreserve.gov, for the decision, the vote, the medians and the dot distribution; ECB and Bank of Japan decisions as reported 10 and 18 September. 3 FOMC press-conference transcript, 16 September 2026, read at source; all Warsh quotations are verbatim from it. 4 August CPI, released 11 September: headline +0.4% month on month and 3.4% year on year, core +0.3% and 2.4%. 5 Market-implied probabilities as reported on 17 and 21 September 2026; these are second-hand from dated coverage rather than read on the exchange's own tool, which refused this desk. 6 Reuters copy read via Yahoo Finance for Monday's oil settlements, the diplomatic detail, the Aramco loadings and the Hormuz transit figures. 7 Correlations computed by this desk from daily adjusted closes over windows ending 21 September 2026; method stated in the text. 8 Monetary Authority of Singapore Monetary Policy Statement, 27 July 2026, quoted verbatim; the MAS site was unreachable and the full text was read from a mirror. 9 Torsten Sløk quoted in Monday's market coverage, read at source. Market-implied rate probabilities are second-hand from dated reporting and are labelled as such. This desk explains markets and does not advise on them; forecasts are flagged as forecasts.

THE INVITATION · A FOUR-THOUSAND-YEAR-OLD CRAFT WITH A RECRUITMENT PROBLEM

Falconry is the only hobby whose central skill is getting back something you deliberately let go.

Its own recruiters lead with the failure rate: of more than three hundred Californians who start in a typical year, fewer than forty finish.

Begin with the definition, because almost everything the word summons is something else. The British Falconers' Club: falconry is "the traditional art of hunting quarry in its natural state and habitat by means of trained hawks."¹ The quarry must be wild and the hunt real. What fails that test is one of three adjacent worlds — raptor rehabilitation; bird-of-prey display, the shows at country fairs, which borrow the technique and hunt nothing; and **abatement**, the commercial scaring of birds off landfills and runways.

The distinction is not pedantry. When campaigners attack "falconry" they usually mean the display tier; when a conservation body defends it, it usually means abatement. The hunting falconer has spent two years being examined, inspected and supervised by the state.

That number is not hidden: the California club prints it on the page meant to attract you.² Arizona puts it at "less than 10 per cent" and spends its recruitment page talking you out of it — the hawk will "merely tolerate your presence, is as affectionate as a stone"; "There will be blood... Falconry is a hunting sport"; "These animals are not pets."³ It is the register of a craft that would rather lose you now than lose a bird later.

"The statistical probability of being able to pass the exam without study is less than one in a million."

That is a state wildlife agency, in official guidance, about a test you must pass before keeping your first

bird.⁴

The world is smaller than its antiquity suggests and harder to count. The International Association for Falconry speaks for **120 organisations across 90 countries** and holds a seat inside the IUCN.⁵ In the United States the figure is somewhere under five thousand licensed falconers, and **nobody publishes an official count** — the federal database that holds the answer does not display one. UNESCO inscribed falconry in 2010 and has extended it three times; it now covers **24 countries**, from the UAE and Qatar to Austria, Mongolia and Korea.⁶ Singapore is not among them, for reasons **p17** makes very clear.

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENT FALCONRY MAKES FOR ITSELF, AND THE REBUTTAL INSIDE IT

The strongest case the craft has is a bird. In 1970 there were **39 known peregrine pairs in the lower forty-eight states**. The Peregrine Fund, founded by falconers, **bred and released more than 4,000 falcons between 1974 and 1997 across 28 states**, using hacking — a falconry technique — and captive propagation, which barely existed before falconers attempted it. Delisted 20 August 1999; 3,005 pairs by 2003.⁷ Its founder **Tom Cade**: "many people felt it couldn't be done." But the Fund's president **Bill Burnham**, same release: "success would not have been possible without ending the use of DDT." Its own president credits the regulatory ban first.

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

Overleaf: the community and the gear — where the tracking equipment costs more than the bird, and where three captive-bred gyrfalcons sold in Abu Dhabi this month for over a million dirhams each. Then the culture, the apprenticeship, and the sceptic.

SOURCES 1 British Falconers' Club, "What is falconry," read at source. 2 California Hawking Club apprenticeship information page, read at source; the "over 300... less than 40" figure is the club's own. 3 Arizona Falconers Association, "Want to be a falconer," read at source; all three quotations verbatim. 4 Virginia Department of Wildlife Resources, *Examination Guidance Document: Falconry Regulations, Facilities & Equipment*, read at source. 5 IUCN member profile for the International Association for Falconry and Conservation of Birds of Prey. A figure of "well over 100,000 falconers" circulates widely; it could not be found on any IAF page readable from this desk and is not printed. The US total is given as a range because the Fish and Wildlife Service publishes no aggregate. 6 UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage inscription 01708: first inscribed 2010, extended 2012, 2016 and 2021, now covering 24 states parties. 7 The Peregrine Fund's own history and delisting release, read at source, for the 1970 pair count, the release programme, the delisting date, the 2003 count and both quotations. Reddit's falconry community, the Falconry Forum, NAFEX and the North American Falconers Association all refused this desk; nothing in this desk is attributed to any of them.

THE GEAR · THE RADIO COSTS MORE THAN THE HAWK

A top telemetry set is four thousand dollars. The classic American apprentice bird is free.

You catch it yourself — then spend more on the equipment to find it again than anyone in the American classifieds asks for a falcon.

The community first, because its shape is a finding. Of the five main gathering places, four refused this desk outright — a bot wall, a Cloudflare challenge, a 403, a closed subreddit. That is characteristic rather than accidental: a licensed, gatekept craft whose members have permits, wild-take politics and welfare campaigners to think about does not live on the open web.¹ What can be mapped is the institutional layer: the IAF sits inside the IUCN, and Britain's Hawk Board lists **nine affiliated bodies** for one country.²

Its running arguments are four. **Captive-bred against passage** — a wild-caught first-year bird you will later release, which federal law steers apprentices toward, against a bred bird with paperwork. **Imprint against parent-reared**: imprints train faster and produce the classic disaster, a screaming, food-aggressive bird. **Telemetry ethics**. And **abatement**, which traditionalists distrust and which, awkwardly, enjoys welfare cover the sporting side does not.³

Now the money. Marshall Radio Telemetry is the category, and its published prices run from a **\$225 Scout transmitter** to complete systems at **\$1,445–\$2,979** and a GPS Pro at **\$2,245–\$4,075**; a receiver alone is \$995. It works on a direct radio link, **not on mobile towers**, which is why it costs what it does and why it works in a desert.⁴ This is not optional equipment: federal rules require **two functioning transmitters on any hybrid being hacked**, and Virginia two on any hybrid flown at all.⁵ Regulators do not mandate redundant tracking for a low-probability event.

Dh2.1m

PAID AT ABU DHABI ON 6 SEPTEMBER FOR ONE PURE ULTRA-WHITE GYRFALCON — ABOUT US\$571,000, A RECORD⁹

One structural note before the birds: most deep hobbies have a visible bespoke layer, and **falconry's**

does not — no public waitlist, deposit figure or lead time from any named bespoke hood maker could be found. That is a result, not a gap: you get in by knowing someone at a field meet.⁶ Marshall, tellingly, sells no custom telemetry at all — it sells *servicing*, at \$30 to \$115 a job.

And the birds. American classifieds this year: gyr-saker hybrids at \$1,000 to \$1,200, an untrained silver gyr at \$800, an aggressive albidus goshawk at \$2,000, augur buzzards at \$6,500. Harris's hawks run \$1,500 from breeders, with a \$200 deposit and a telephone interview you must pass before you may pay it.⁷ The classic apprentice bird costs nothing: you trap a passage red-tail yourself, and it is the hardest thing you will do.

THE CUTTING EDGE · AND THE DH2.1 MILLION FALCON, SOLD THIS MONTH

Three genuine changes. **Marshall's GPS Pro** doubles transmitter endurance from two or three days to four or five — a bird lost on day three used to be a bird whose radio was dying. The maker publishes no launch date and none is asserted here. **Drone and kite training is now a catalogue item**: a major supplier stocks parachute lures for quadcopters at \$57.95–\$74.95 beside helium balloons at \$399.95–\$649.95. And **Gulf falcon racing has been quantified** — the *telwah* lure now exists as an app-controlled device that logs the bird's speed to a database, and January's Fazza Racing Cup reported results **to three decimal places of a second**.⁸

Then the top of the market. On **6 September a pure ultra-white gyrfalcon sold at Abu Dhabi for Dh2.1 million — about US\$571,000**, the highest ever paid for a falcon at the exhibition. Two more from the same American breeder went for Dh1.5m and Dh1.1m; the Dh1.5m sale had been announced as a record eight days earlier, and was beaten.⁹ **The dearest falcon on earth cost 571 times the dearest bird in the American classifieds.**

SOURCES 1 Access attempts made 21–22 September 2026; NAFEX, the North American Falconers Association, the Falconry Forum and the falconry subreddit were all unreadable, and nothing is attributed to any of them. 2 The Hawk Board's own affiliations page, read at source. 3 The captive-bred, imprint and apprentice restrictions are set out at 50 CFR 21.82, read via Cornell's Legal Information Institute; the abatement carve-out is from the BC SPCA's published position statement. 4 Marshall Radio Telemetry's own worldwide store, prices and system specifications read at source on 21–22 September 2026. 5 50 CFR 21.82 for the hacking requirement and the Virginia Department of Wildlife Resources guidance document for the flying requirement. 6 Repeated searching found no public bespoke-hood waitlist, deposit or lead time; named makers and the published hood, bell and perch prices are from Ben Long Falconry, Mike's Falconry Supplies and Northwoods Falconry, read from their own live catalogues. 7 raptorsforsale.com classified listings with 2026 posting dates, and Coulson Harris's Hawks' own ordering page, both read at source. 8 Northwoods Falconry's catalogue for the drone and balloon pricing; the UAE Government Media Office for the Fazza Falcons Racing Cup of 17 January 2026 and its timing; Marshall's own product page for the GPS Pro specification, which carries no date. Two widely-repeated claims — a falconry-edition fishing drone and a 5G-based telemetry system — could not be verified and are not printed. 9 *The National* and a corroborating trade wire, both read at source, for the 6 September 2026 sale, the dirham and dollar figures, the breeder and the two further sales.

THE CULTURE · THE WORDS, THE YEARS, AND THE LAW THAT ENDS IT HERE

Every object on a 1920 National Geographic plate is still sold today under the same name.

Dutch hood, bewit, jesses, swivel, leash — a hundred and six years, and the catalogue has barely moved. In Singapore, possessing the bird they are for carries two years.

The path in is a licensing ladder. An **apprentice** may be twelve, needs a sponsor who has held a general licence two years, and may keep one bird — not an imprint, not a nestling. And it is not two years of membership: the rules require flying and hunting the raptor “for at least 4 months in each year.”²

One correction, because it circulates widely: **the federal rules specify no mews dimensions at all** — the standard is performance-based, and the familiar “eight by eight” is not federal law. Virginia’s standard beats any number anyway: a window barred vertically, “spaced narrower than the width of the bird’s body.”¹

Cost: the California club’s line items come to about **\$1,439** before gear, including **\$259 for a game warden to look at your shed**. But the currency is time — California asks “a half-hour a day, every day”; Arizona, “an hour a day, every day.”³ That, not the radio, is what the 87 per cent are failing.

THE SCEPTIC · A DEFLECTED WELFARE CASE, AND AN ENDANGERED FALCON

The serious objection is not PETA’s but the BC SPCA’s: it opposes keeping and breeding raptors to hunt, on grounds including husbandry, wild take and **birds lost or released**. Falconry’s governing body answers with analogies — a controlled diet is like an athlete’s, tethering like a dog’s lead.⁴ **Those are analogies, not evidence.**

Then the saker, Endangered since 2004 on a 53–75 per cent decline, with trapping for Gulf falconers estimated at four thousand birds a year in Saudi Arabia alone. Falconry’s own consultancy has published this: “**its Endangered status could potentially hinder programmes to develop sustainable harvests for Arabic falconry by reducing opportunities to engage in a legal trade.**”⁵ Beside three gyrfalcons clearing a million dirhams each this month (**p16**): does a half-million-dollar white gyr relieve pressure on wild sakers, or prove that falcons are worth stealing?

And the Singapore answer, which is no. The Wildlife (Protected Wildlife Species) Rules 2020 list, at items 2 and 3 of the bird schedule, **Falconiformes spp. and Strigiformes spp.** — “spp.” meaning every species in the taxon: **every eagle, falcon, hawk, vulture and owl on earth**. Keeping one without approval carries **up to S\$50,000 or two years**, and on 14 September NParks seized 101 illegally kept animals in raids.⁶ To fly one instead: Yorkshire, an hour on the glove, **£40**; Kent, a full day, **£155**; Dubai, **AED 3,995**.⁷

NEXT DESCENTS — PICK TOMORROW’S RABBIT HOLE

Leathercraft — the hand saddle-stitch, and a tool economy that never depreciates.

Glassblowing & lampworking — a furnace in a shared studio, and the hour you cannot pause.

Home cheesemaking — cultures, rennet, and a cave in a spare fridge.

SOURCES 1 Virginia Department of Wildlife Resources falconry guidance document, read at source, for the 105-question examination, the 84-question pass mark, the one-time nature of the test and the mews and weathering-area standards including the window-bar specification. 2 50 CFR 21.82, read via Cornell’s Legal Information Institute, for the three permit classes, minimum ages, sponsor requirement, bird limits, the four-months-a-year practice requirement, the apprentice imprint and nestling restrictions, and the performance-based facility standard quoted above; the federal rule contains no square-footage figure. 3 California Hawking Club apprenticeship page for all licence, membership and inspection costs and the half-hour commitment; Arizona Falconers Association for the hour-a-day figure; The Modern Apprentice for the training-time quotations. Equipment prices as sourced on **p16**. 4 BC SPCA position statement on falconry and the International Association for Falconry’s own welfare position paper, both read at source; quotations verbatim. 5 International Wildlife Consultants Ltd — a falconry-sector consultancy, not a conservation NGO — on the saker’s conservation status; the quoted sentence is verbatim from its own page. The IUCN Red List species page itself returned 403 to this desk, so the current category should be treated as reported by that source rather than read at the Red List. Trapping figures are published estimates and some are dated; they are labelled as estimates. 6 Animal & Veterinary Service list of animals that may be kept as pets; Wildlife (Protected Wildlife Species) Rules 2020, the Schedule, Part 2, items 2 and 3; Wildlife Act 1965 sections 5C, 8 and 9, all read at Singapore Statutes Online; the amendment annotation is “[Act 15 of 2026 wef 01/07/2026]”. NParks news release of 14 September 2026 for the seizures. 7 Mandai’s own page for “Predators on Wings”; the National Centre for Birds of Prey, The Hawking Centre and Platinum Heritage for the experience prices, each read at the operator’s own site. No dedicated falconry-handling operator could be verified in Malaysia.

MEASUREMENT · THE WRONG HAND ON THE DYNAMOMETER

Being weak predicted nothing. Being lopsided predicted a great deal.

Across 8,132 adults followed for nine years, low grip strength on its own carried a hazard ratio whose confidence interval crossed one. A ten per cent gap between the hands carried 1.23.

Grip strength is the most-cited cheap proxy in longevity medicine, and the number everybody records is the better hand. A cohort published on 17 September suggests the informative quantity is the one nobody writes down: the difference between them.¹ It drew 8,132 Chinese adults aged 45 to 80, free of cardiometabolic multimorbidity at baseline, and followed them from 2011 to 2020. Asymmetry was a ten per cent or greater difference between hands. Over the period, 848 — 10.4 per cent — developed two or more of diabetes, heart disease and stroke.

1.09 (0.76–1.56)

FULLY ADJUSTED HAZARD RATIO FOR LOW GRIP STRENGTH ALONE. THE INTERVAL CROSSES ONE: NO SIGNAL¹

The four groups separate cleanly. Asymmetric but not weak: **hazard ratio 1.23** (1.06–1.42). Asymmetric and weak: **1.67** (1.27–2.20). Weak but symmetric: 1.09 (0.76–1.56) — which is to say nothing at all.¹

THE SCEPTIC · AND THIS IS A GOOD ONE, BECAUSE IT IS PUBLISHED AND IT IS SPECIFIC

Pengxiang Wang and Mengxuan Liu, writing in *Geriatrics & Gerontology International* on 2 August, went at exactly this literature. Their central objection: “handgrip asymmetry should be interpreted in relation to handedness and movement history rather than solely as a pathological imbalance.”³ Tennis, badminton, throwing sports, occupational loading and an old injury all manufacture a durable ten per cent gap in a perfectly healthy arm. A racquet habit is not a disease.

Their second point is about the instrument: “maximal voluntary performance may also be influenced by motivation, confidence, perceived fatigue, pain-related apprehension” — a single squeeze cannot separate a structural imbalance from a bad morning. The cohort’s own limits point the same way: outcomes are self-reported, and the associations attenuated in the restricted sensitivity analysis.

THE NUMBER FOR A FORTY-FIVE-YEAR-OLD, FROM FORTY THOUSAND OF THEM

A second paper, published the same day in *Diabetes, Obesity and Metabolism*, sits on this reader’s demographic exactly: 39,197 UK adults, **mean age 45.8**. Each additional millilitre per kilogram per minute of peak oxygen uptake was associated with a 2.9 per cent lower count of metabolic-syndrome traits and a **6.0 per cent lower prevalence**; lowest fitness quintile against highest, 2.4 times the trait count and **5.4 times the prevalence**.²

39,197

UK ADULTS, MEAN AGE 45.8 — 69 PER CENT MALE AND SELF-SELECTED FROM PRIVATE HEALTHCARE²

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE CURVE IS STEEPEST, AND WHAT IT IS NOT

The splines are the useful part: the relationship is graded and non-linear, and **steepest at the low-fitness end**.² The first increment of fitness buys the most, which is the opposite of how training is usually sold to people who already train. The strongest single trait association was central obesity.

The caveats are the authors’ own and not small: cross-sectional, so no temporality and no causal claim; peak oxygen uptake **estimated from submaximal protocols, not measured**; 69 per cent male and self-selected from private healthcare. Separately, work published in February is a standing caution for anyone reading a ring or a strap: test-retest agreement 3.7 years apart was 0.62 for steps, and correcting for that dilution moved a steps-to-heart-disease hazard ratio from 0.87 to 0.80.⁴ One snapshot is a noisier measure of you than it feels. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 Huang Y, Huang L, Gao Y, Wang K, Shao J, Wu H, Yu J, “Handgrip strength asymmetry and cardiometabolic multimorbidity in Chinese middle-aged and older adults: a longitudinal cohort study,” *Experimental Gerontology* 2026;225:113329, 17 September 2026, DOI 10.1016/j.exger.2026.113329, PMID 42753932; sample, definitions, event count, all four hazard ratios with intervals and the sleep interaction p-values are from the published abstract. 2 Willis SA, Phillipp A, Deighton K, ... King JA, “Higher Cardiorespiratory Fitness Is Associated With a Lower Burden of Metabolic Syndrome Traits: A Cross-Sectional Analysis of 39,197 UK Adults,” *Diabetes, Obesity and Metabolism*, online 17 September 2026, DOI 10.1111/dom.71367, PMID 42755173; the per-unit associations, the quintile comparisons, the spline shape and every limitation quoted above are the authors’ own. 3 Wang P, Liu M, commentary in *Geriatrics & Gerontology International*, 2 August 2026, read at source; both quotations verbatim. 4 Zisou et al., *International Journal of Epidemiology* 55(2), 20 February 2026, on repeat accelerometry in 3,138 UK Biobank participants and regression-dilution correction.

THE DIARY • SEVENTEEN DAYS TO THE STREET CIRCUIT

The three-day grandstands have already gone. Two things on this page close before October does.

Every row was re-checked at a promoter, a venue or an official ticketing page. Three widely-listed items are missing because they have not been announced — see the notes.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW • PLAN AHEAD

- 2 OCT

Octoburst! — the children's festival
 ESPLANADE • **EVERY PROGRAMME FREE**, CAPACITY-LIMITED — REGISTER THE WEEK BEFORE¹
- 9-11 OCT

★ Formula 1 Singapore Grand Prix
 MARINA BAY • THE FIRST **SPRINT** WEEKEND HERE, SO SATURDAY CARRIES A RACE • THREE-DAY GRANDSTANDS **SOLD OUT**; ZONE 4 WALKABOUT \$S198-368 A DAY²
- 13-22 NOV

Singapore Writers Festival — “Hidden in Plain Sight”
 CIVIC DISTRICT • FESTIVAL PASS **\$S30**, YOUTH PASS \$S15 • 100+ PROGRAMMES¹
- 4-6 DEC

★ Singapore International Marathon
 MARINA BAY • MARATHON, HALF, 10KM, 5KM AND A KIDS DASH • **REGISTRATION CLOSES 30 SEPTEMBER**, EIGHT DAYS AWAY. ENTRY FEES WERE NOT REACHABLE⁴
- 11 DEC-4 APR

★ Pop after Pop: Art around Us
 NATIONAL GALLERY • **\$S15** CITIZENS AND PRS, \$S25 OTHERS • 200+ WORKS, WARHOL AND HARING BESIDE SOUTHEAST ASIAN PIONEERS • THE FIRST GUGGENHEIM COLLABORATION, AND THE ONE BLOCKBUSTER THAT WORKS FOR AN ADULT AND A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD AT ONCE⁵

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

- 31 OCT-28 MAR

Mariko Mori — All That Shines
 MORI ART MUSEUM • ~40 WORKS OVER THREE DECADES • WEEKDAY ¥2,800, WEEKEND ¥3,000 • **JUNIOR-HIGH AND UNDER FREE**⁶
- 8-22 NOV

★ Grand Sumo — Kyushu Basho
 FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER • **THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN SITE SAYS SOLD OUT, ALL DATES**; JANUARY IN TOKYO IS NOT TAKING NEW ORDERS. DATES ARE SECONDARY — CONFIRM BEFORE FLYING⁷
- 26 NOV-11 DEC

Autumn colour — the official forecast window
 TOKYO GINKGO **26 NOV**, MAPLE 29 NOV; KYOTO **MAPLE 11 DEC**; OSAKA 4 DEC • LATER THAN AVERAGE NATIONWIDE; REVISED EARLY OCTOBER⁸
- 11-13 DEC

★ Tokyo Comic Con
 MAKUHARI MESSE • THREE-DAY PASS **¥9,900; UNDER-18 ¥1,000, UNDER-15 ¥500** — THE CHEAPEST BIG DAY OUT HERE • NICOLAS CAGE, CHARLIE COX, THE PHELPS TWINS⁹
- 11-31 JAN

Australian Open 2027
 MELBOURNE PARK • MAIN DRAW FROM **SUN 17 JAN**, FINALS 30 AND 31 • PUBLIC TICKETS RELEASED; NO PRICE BANDS PUBLISHED¹⁰
- 4-11 FEB

Sapporo Snow Festival 2027
 ODORI, SUSUKINO AND TSUDOME • SCULPTURES LIT TO 10PM • CORE SITES FREE¹¹

PLANNING NOTES • THREE THINGS THIS DESK WILL NOT PRINT AS HAPPENING

Post Malone's National Stadium show, this Friday, is postponed. The promoter's own page carries the notice: the concert “has been postponed” and ticket holders “will receive a full refund through the original payment method.” No new date. It was part of a blanket postponement of the Asia leg — this desk flagged the date as unsafe at No. 85 and it is recorded as dead, so it appears here as a correction and nowhere as a listing.³

Christmas Wonderland has not been announced. The official site still shows only the 2025 closure and Gardens by the Bay's own calendar lists no 2026 edition. Dates circulating elsewhere are last year's. The same calendar does confirm that **Satay by the Bay closes from 1 October** for waterfront redevelopment.¹²

Tokyo's winter illuminations have not been announced either — Marunouchi, Roppongi Hills, Midtown, Shibuya. Every date in circulation is the 2025-26 season; venues historically confirm in October for a mid-November start.

THE CHATTER • THE ONE TO BOOK THIS WEEK

One thing before the weekend: enter the marathon — registration shuts on the 30th, and the Kids Dash is the rare family entry that does not go to a ballot. Marina Bay Sands refused this desk on every path, so nothing from the ArtScience Museum appears above.

SOURCES 1 Esplanade's own festival page for Octoburst! and singaporewritersfestival.com for passes and pricing. 2 singaporegp.sg entertainment and ticket pages, read at source, for the Sprint format, the sold-out grandstands, the walkabout bands and the line-up. 3 livenation.sg event pages for Guns N' Roses and for the Post Malone postponement notice, both read at source; Ticketmaster Singapore returned 403 and no resale figure is used. 4 singaporeinternationalmarathon.com for the race weekend, the categories and the closing date; the fees pages returned 404. 5 nationalgallery.sg exhibition page and media release for dates, pricing, scale and the Guggenheim collaboration. 6 mori.art.museum. 7 The Japan Sumo Association's own English site for the sold-out notice and the official reseller for the waiting list; the 8-22 November range is secondary, as flagged in the row. 8 Japan Meteorological Corporation autumn-foliage forecast issued 2 September 2026. 9 tokyocomiccon.jp ticket page and guest announcements. 10 ausopen.com dates announcement. 11 sapporo.travel event page. 12 christmaswonderland.sg and the Gardens by the Bay events calendar, both read at source.

THE TABLE • THREE OPENINGS, AND NOT ONE OF THEM TAKES A BOOKING

A Shibuya one-dish house, a Hong Kong steak chain trading up, and a French bistro pricing itself under the tower it sits in.

Two are too new to judge and say so. The third has been reviewed twice, and both verdicts landed on the same three words.

Mukai opened in August at Plaza Singapura, its first outlet outside Japan. In Shibuya it occupies a converted townhouse with tatami; here it is a basement unit two minutes from Dhoby Ghaut. The proposition is one dish — the Kaiho Don, “sea treasure,” a tower of sashimi over seasoned rice, graded from Nami through Tokujo to the Goku Goku with chūtoro, uni and ikura. The ritual is two-part: eat the bowl, then have warm dashi poured over what is left and finish it as ochazuke.¹

It has been reviewed, and the consensus is precise and slightly deflating. HungryGoWhere found the seafood genuinely comparable to Tokyo — then flagged uni with “an overly briny, fishy note,” one-dimensional broths, and a room without the original’s charm, advising “tempered expectations.” Middle Class scored it 3.5 out of 5: the ochazuke “stood out,” but “the quality of fish could be improved” and “the steep price point makes it hard to justify a dedicated visit.”² Two outlets arriving independently at *worth one visit* — the most damning phrase in the 2026 Singapore dining vocabulary.

Bowls run S\$19.90 to S\$79.90++, sets S\$68 to S\$99++, though published figures differ between reviews. Not halal. **No reservations:** the launch offer was capped at eight groups a day, and weekend waits persist. Go at 11.30 sharp, or take the counter alone.

Bari Bari Grand opened on 14 August in the arcade at the Capitol Kempinski — the premium flagship of a Hong Kong hotstone teppan chain whose Tampines outlet does steaks from S\$22.90++. The Grand format trades up to A4 and A5 Miyazaki wagyu, wagyu tartare and lobster thermidor, all finished tableside on hot stone, with a free-flow Japanese “gourmet bar” on every teppan order.³

THE BUZZ • TOO NEW TO CALL, AND THE HONEST REASON WHY

There is no substantive review of Bari Bari Grand.

There is round-up coverage and promotion write-ups, and this desk will not manufacture a verdict out of either. The only real signal is commercial: an A4/A5 wagyu experience priced at chain-teppan levels — either the value story of the season or a bet on margin. Its own prices are unpublished.³

It is the only opening here that **takes reservations.**

And the mall’s directory says 13 Stamford Road while the restaurant says 15; go to 15, unit #01-82.

Les Canons opened this month at street level in the new IOI Central Boulevard tower — a Parisian corner bistro from the ilLido group, pitched deliberately below its usual register: breakfast from 8.30, all-day dining to ten, fifty-odd French wines by the glass. Reporting puts the whole carte under S\$22, which this desk could not confirm on the menu and prints as reported.⁴ No reservations; closed Sundays — which tells you how weekday the catchment is. Too new for a verdict.

THE SCEPTIC • THE OTHER HALF OF THE LEDGER

Roughly forty restaurants and cafés opened here across August and September. The other half of the ledger is less photographed: a compilation of trade-ministry data records **2,431 retail food establishment closures between 1 January and 23 October 2025**, more than 36 per cent of them businesses registered under three years — about **307 a month in early 2025, against 254 in 2024.**⁵ **This desk could not reach the statistics department to verify that at the primary release, and prints it as a secondary compilation, flagged.**

Which makes the detail these three share worth a second look. None takes a booking. It reads as confidence. It reads equally well as a refusal to carry the cost of a booking book in a market where three hundred kitchens a month stop answering the phone.

SOURCES 1 mukai.sg and the mall operator’s own store listing, read at source, for the concept, the grades, the dashi finish, the address and the hours. 2 HungryGoWhere and Middle Class reviews, both read at source; all quoted phrases are verbatim from them, and the price discrepancy between the two is noted in the text rather than resolved. 3 Capitol Singapore’s own directory for the unit, hours and telephone number, and Eatbook for the menu detail and the Tampines reference pricing; Eatbook states explicitly that the flagship’s prices are not yet confirmed. 4 lesanons.sg for the concept, hours, wine list and reservations policy; the sub-S\$22 carte is from secondary coverage and is flagged as such above. 5 Trade-ministry closure figures and monthly averages as compiled by a third-party analysis; singstat.gov.sg returned 403 to this desk and the primary release was not read. Venues previously covered by this desk are excluded by the Table ledger and none appears above.

WALK-IN ONLY

TOO NEW TO CALL

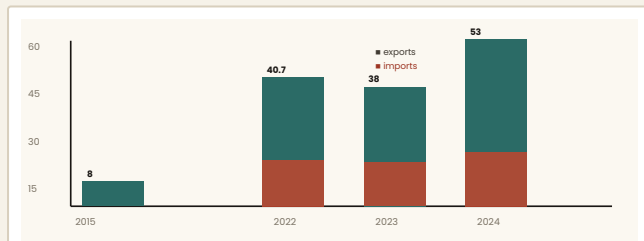
THE UNDERCURRENT · FIJI

The root that asks forgiveness now has a spot price.

Fiji's kava exports have gone from eight million dollars to fifty-three in nine years. Ninety-two per cent of the value in this crop is still domestic — which is precisely why a few hundred bars in Florida can reprice a Fijian village.

A bundle of *waka* — dried kava root, bound with plastic tape — is not a commodity in Fiji. It is the object you carry when you arrive somewhere you have no right to be. Presented at *sevusevu*, it asks permission: to enter a village, to marry, to apologise, to bury someone. The whole point of the transaction is that the price is not the point.

It has a price now, and it is moving. Green yaqona at the farm gate has gone from under ten Fijian dollars a kilogram to nearly sixteen or seventeen; a quarter-parcel of unpounded root in a Suva market has gone from ten dollars to between fifteen and eighteen.¹ **Manjeet Milan**, who trades as Milan's Kava at Makoi Market in Nasinu, put it to the *Fiji Times* in January: "Right now the biggest problem is the price. There is not enough supply and the price is high." And: "while kava is being exported at high prices, local consumers and vendors continue to struggle."²



Fiji's kava trade, FJ\$ millions. The 2024 export figure is reported at FJ\$47.8m provisionally, FJ\$53m and "over \$54m" in three Fijian outlets; the highest published figure is plotted and the range is stated. Imports, in vermilion, reached FJ\$17.4m in 2024. *Meridian* original, from *Fiji Times* and *Fiji Sun* reporting of Bureau of Statistics data.³

The export line is the one everyone points at. In 2015 Fiji sold FJ\$8 million of kava abroad. In 2024 it sold 730 tonnes for a figure its own press reports variously as FJ\$47.8 million, FJ\$53 million and "over \$54 million" — provisional against revised statistics, and this essay prints the spread rather than choosing.³ A more than six-fold rise in nine years, off

roughly **17,200 farmers in 14,532 households**, forty-two per cent of them in the Northern Division.

"There is not enough supply and the price is high."

Four things changed at once, and they compounded. Australia opened a commercial import channel from December 2021, and **128 tonnes of Fijian kava crossed in the thirty-two months to July 2024**, turning a diaspora product into a retail one.⁴ Kava bars spread across twenty-odd American states. A disease arrived. And then, on 22 December 2025, the United States Food and Drug Administration is reported to have confirmed that kava mixed with water, as a single-ingredient conventional food, would not generally be regulated as a food additive — the regulatory unlock that lets the root into mainstream retail.⁵

That last item needs a flag, because it is load-bearing and this desk could not read it at the FDA. The determination is known through an industry press release and subsequent trade coverage; the agency's own correspondence was not locatable. Hawaii and Michigan have since treated kava beverage as generally recognised as safe. The direction is corroborated; the primary document is not in hand, and the reader should know which.

Hold the shape of it, because the rest of this essay turns on it. A root that takes half a decade to grow, farmed by seventeen thousand people on a group of islands with 930,000 inhabitants, is now being bought by a retail market on two other continents that was opened by a customs decision in one capital and a regulatory letter in another. Nobody in either building was thinking about Bua.

SOURCES 1 *Fiji Sun*, "Kava exports rise, boosting incomes but pushing local prices higher," 26 August 2025, read at source, for the farm-gate and market price movements and for the exporter quoted on p22. 2 *Fiji Times*, "Market vendor struggles with rising kava prices," 16 January 2026, read at source; both Milan quotations verbatim. 3 *Fiji Times* feature, "Strengthening the kava sector," 9 February 2026, for the 730 tonnes, the FJ\$53m figure, the 2015 comparison, the farmer and household counts, the regional split and the 2017 value-chain estimate; *Fiji Times*, 21 February 2025, for the 2022–24 export and import series including the FJ\$47.8m provisional figure and FJ\$17.4m of imports; *Fiji Sun*, 6 December 2025, for "over \$54 million." The three figures are reported rather than reconciled. 4 FBC News, 2 September 2024, for the Australian import volume; a figure in the same report of "380,000 tonnes across the Pacific" is an evident units error and is not used. 5 The FDA determination of 22 December 2025 as reported in an industry press release and subsequent trade coverage, read at source; the agency's own letters could not be located and the claim is flagged in the text accordingly.

A crop that takes three to five years in the ground cannot answer a price signal. The supply response to the boom of 2025 arrives, at the earliest, in 2029 — and into that lag walked a virus. In December the Permanent Secretary for Agriculture, **Dr Andrew Tukuna**, put it plainly: “The recent survey undertaken by the ministry reveals that around 20 per cent of kava farmers in the country are affected or infected with kava dieback disease.”¹ One farm in five, and there is no cure.

Demand inflected, supply could not move, disease took a fifth of the farms. The predictable thing happened to the price, and then the less predictable thing happened to the village. **Rosa Chute**, a farmer at Sevaci: “Here in our community, we experience at least three cases of kava theft every week.”²

“Here in our community, we experience at least three cases of kava theft every week.”

The response has been money and law: the kava farming programme quadrupled in the budget, a research programme revived, and a Kava Bill and National Kava Policy in draft.³ The draft’s own verdict: demand “continues to grow, but regulatory measures have been weak.” (*The budget figures come from a report this desk could not open at source.*)

And here the story turns, because the minister does not blame the exporters. **Tomasi Tunabuna**, Minister for Agriculture, in January: “I think the biggest worry now is, apart from the disease, is the high consumption, unnecessary consumption of kava.” Fewer are growing it; “a lot of people plant yaqona, they don’t look after the yaqona.” And: “There is quite a big shift in how people drink kava, a lot of wastage.”⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THE STRONGEST REBUTTAL COMES FROM INSIDE THE MINISTRY

That is the most serious objection to this essay’s own frame, and it comes from the top of the relevant department: the shortage is domestic, not foreign. Fewer growers, neglected plantings, changed drinking habits, waste. Dieback is “just part of the solution.” On this reading the export market is a scapegoat for a supply failure Fiji created at home.

A second sceptic, better evidenced: **this has happened before and the price came down**. After Cyclone Winston flattened plantings in 2016, the 2017 shortage produced the identical grievance structure — exporters told to meet local demand first, middlemen blamed — and the exporter Anukar Dayal predicted publicly that high prices would “lead to a drop in its price” within two or three years.⁵ Anyone calling 2026 structural must explain why 2017 was cyclical. The answer is on **p23**, and it is not that the minister is wrong; it is that he describes one side of a price.

Because the other side is now visible in the trade data, and it is stranger than a shortage. In 2024 Fiji exported somewhere between FJ\$47.8 and FJ\$53 million of kava — and **imported FJ\$17.4 million of it**, up from FJ\$13.8 million the year before.⁶ The kava heartland buys back a third as much as it sells.

Then, on 8 November 2025, the Solomon Islands air-freighted its **first-ever commercial kava export**. The destination was Fiji, and its kavalactone content was 11.8 per cent, among the highest in the Pacific.² Vanuatu takes the opposite view of such imports: its kava industry association says foreign kava “must not be permitted under any circumstance.”⁷

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE LOCAL PRESS RECORDS, AND WHAT THIS DESK COULD NOT REACH

Fijian subreddits and Facebook groups were not reachable from this desk, so nothing here is drawn from social media. What follows is what Fijian outlets report about Fijian feeling, and is labelled as that. Both the *Fiji Times* and the *Fiji Sun* frame it as export against village. The ministry’s shift of blame toward domestic drinkers, in a country where the tanoa is a civic institution, is the likely flashpoint. **Krishan Lal**, an exporter at Bulileka near Labasa, ships half a tonne to California every three months and buys it “from middlemen in the market” — the mechanism by which a Californian order reaches a Fijian stall.¹

SOURCES 1 *Fiji Sun*, 6 December 2025, for the Tukuna quotation and the outreach package; *Fiji Sun*, 26 August 2025, for Krishan Lal. 2 Pacific Media Network, 10 November 2025, read at source, for the Rosa Chute quotation, the Solomon Islands consignment, its date, its kavalactone content and the Fijian assistant minister’s remark. 3 *Fiji Times* feature, 9 February 2026, for the draft National Kava Policy’s targets and its quoted verdict; the budget figures for the farming and research programmes come from a report that returned 403 to this desk and are printed as reported, not as read at source. 4 *Fiji Times*, “Excessive usage hits kava supply,” 27 January 2026, read at source; all Tunabuna quotations verbatim. 5 *Fiji Times*, 18 August 2017, read at source, for the post-Winston shortage and the Dayal prediction. 6 *Fiji Times*, 21 February 2025, for the import series. 7 *Vanuatu Daily Post*, for the Vanuatu Kava Industry Association’s position; the association chairman’s name was not captured at source and no individual is named here.

Here is the argument, in three turns, and the first one is arithmetic. The export boom is small. A 2017 estimate put the gross income of Fiji's whole kava value chain at about FJ\$320 million, of which **ninety-two per cent came from domestic sales.**¹ Fifty-three million dollars of exports sits on top of that as a tail.

And that is exactly why it hurts. A marginal foreign buyer need not be large to set the price for a crop with a five-year lag and a virus in a fifth of its farms. **This is not a takeover. It is a price transmission** — a small external shock repricing a very large domestic ritual, which is how globalisation actually reaches a village. Not through ownership. Through the last kilogram sold.

Not through ownership. Through the last kilogram sold.

The second turn the trade data has quietly conceded. Fiji exports and imports; the Solomon Islands sends its first commercial consignment to Fiji, with a higher kavalactone content than most Fijian root; exporters buy through middlemen and blend. **"Fijian kava" is becoming an appellation rather than an origin** — and the moment a commodity becomes a label is the moment its farmers lose the pricing power they briefly held.

The third turn is about the buyer, because the American market that unlocked in December is not straightforwardly drinking what Fiji grows. The Centers for Disease Control reported in April on kava-related poison-centre calls: **42 in 2010, 203 in 2025**, and eight deaths across twenty-five years.² The striking figure is not the growth. It is that **kratom was a co-exposure in thirty per cent of 2025 cases** — ten times the rate for alcohol or benzodiazepines.

Read carefully, not sensationally: it is a study of polysubstance use in American bars, not of a Fijian drink, and its 383 per cent is measured from a 2010 trough far below the 2000 level. But note what the December accommodation covered — **kava mixed with water, single ingredient**. Nearly everything driving the commercial growth sits outside that sentence. The regulator legitimised the traditional preparation while the market expanded in the adulterated one.

SOURCES ¹ *Fiji Times* feature, 9 February 2026, read at source, for the 2017 value-chain estimate and the 92 per cent domestic share. ² Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, *Morbidity and Mortality Weekly Report* Vol. 75 No. 12, April 2026 (Towers, Williams, Holstege and Farah, University of Virginia Blue Ridge Poison Center), read at source, for the poison-centre call counts, the percentage change, the kratom and other co-exposure shares, the serious-outcome proportions and the death total. The framing caution about the 2010 baseline is this desk's own reading of the published series. Trade and price figures are as sourced on **p21** and **p22**. The prior Australian coverage referred to above is an ABC News feature of 6 July 2025, which returned 403 to this desk; it is acknowledged rather than drawn upon.

THE SCEPTIC · AND THE REASON TO THINK 2026 IS NOT 2017

The cyclical case, made on **p22**, is genuinely strong: Fiji has run this experiment before and the price came back down. What is different this time is that the 2016 shock was to *supply* and this one is to *demand* — and a demand shock that arrives with a regulatory unlock, a new Australian retail channel and a disease in a fifth of the farms does not resolve on a planting cycle. The honest position is that this could still be a cycle. The evidence that it is not is the import line, which has no cyclical explanation at all.

The other caution is this essay's own: an Australian broadcaster reported the "boom hurts families" story fourteen months ago, and the harder thing lies underneath it.

Which leaves the *sevusevu*. The *yaqona* bundle is the instrument by which a Fijian asks for something — forgiveness, permission, a welcome — and its power has always rested on a deliberate silence about what it is worth. Give that object a spot price and you have not destroyed the ceremony. You have made it legible to a market, which is a slower and more complete thing.

Fiji's answer is to build a wall of quality around the word: a Kava Bill, a national policy, standards, certified noble varieties. A Pacific *appellation d'origine contrôlée*. It may genuinely be the only way to keep the value at home, and the government deserves credit for reaching for it early rather than late. It is also, precisely, the moment at which a sacrament finishes becoming a product — because an appellation is a promise made to a buyer, and the *tanoa* never had a buyer before.

THE THREADS · WHERE THIS ISSUE HAS BEEN

The book keeps returning this morning to the distance between an instrument and the thing it is aimed at. A central bank raised rates at an oil price its own chairman conceded it cannot touch (**p14**). Seventy strikes on Russian refineries left their earnings higher than last year (**p3**). A rule against phones in classrooms was followed by more phones in classrooms (**p12**). Export controls written around one machine did not prevent the pitch they were written to prevent (**p7**). Fiji is the same shape inverted, and that is why it closes the issue. Nobody aimed anything at a village in Bua or Cakaudrove. A few hundred bars in Florida, a customs decision in Canberra, a letter in Maryland — and the reach turned out to be total.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

How far a thing actually reaches

A reporter asked the chairman of the Federal Reserve how a quarter-point rate rise was supposed to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. He answered honestly: it cannot. “We cannot affect any individual price.” Four days later oil fell three and a half dollars, because Saudi Arabia loaded fourteen million barrels onto seven ships and the tankers started moving. The instrument aimed at the problem did not reach it; the thing that did had nothing to do with him.

It kept happening. Ukraine has struck Russian refineries more than seventy times this year, and Russian refining earned sixteen per cent more in the first half than it did last. Singapore created a criminal offence carrying a year in prison for a breach about five people a year commit. Schools banned phones and phone use in class went up, because the rule stayed and the enforcement quietly left.

And then the other direction, which is worse, because nobody chose it. A falconer spends four thousand dollars on a radio to reach a bird he let go on purpose. A few hundred kava bars in Florida, a customs decision in Canberra and a letter from a regulator in Maryland have between them raised the price of the root a Fijian carries when he asks a village for permission to enter it. Nothing was aimed at Bua. The reach was total anyway. The useful question is not how strong your lever is. It is how long.

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A note on method. Load-bearing figures were read on the pages that carry them: the Danish, Chinese and American governments' own releases; Singapore's Ministries of Home Affairs and Manpower directly; the National Environment Agency's live air-quality endpoint, read at five o'clock this morning; the Federal Reserve's own statement and press-conference transcript; the US Code of Federal Regulations and Singapore Statutes Online for the falconry law; and each maker's own catalogue for every price printed. The equity-bond correlations on **p14** were computed here. Hosts that refused this desk are named where their absence matters: Reuters, the BBC, the Associated Press, CNN, the Straits Times, Marina Bay Sands, Singapore's statistics department and Reddit were all unreachable, and nothing in this issue is attributed to any of them. What could not be verified is flagged in place or omitted — among them the United States kava determination, three Fijian export figures that do not agree, a Russian drone count and a camera battery rating two publications report differently. Market levels are Monday's closes except the bitcoin and currency prints. The Macro Desk explains markets and does not advise on them; the Family and Fitness desks carry general guidance, not medical advice. *Twelve Desks · One World*.